

Legion of Boom vs The Dark Side

Two Eras, One Identity

Motivation: Being born and raised in Seattle, WA, I have been lucky enough to see the Seahawks climb to the top of the NFL mountain twice and be crowned Super Bowl Champions. From the legendary Legion of Boom in 2013 to the emergence of The Dark Side in 2025, defense was the heartbeat of these teams and it was the backbone that helped bring a parade to Seattle. Watching both of these teams shutdown offenses sparked my interest in exploring how these squads compare beyond traditional statistics and fan debates. This project is a personal and analytical deep dive into two iconic Seahawks defenses and the data behind their dominance.

Background: The 2013 Seahawks “Legion of Boom” defense is widely regarded as one of the greatest defenses in NFL history. A season remembered for completely overwhelming opponents on their way to the Super Bowl, that ended with the Denver Broncos, the most statistically explosive offense ever, held to just eight points under the bright lights. Over a decade later, the 2025 Seahawks defense, nicknamed “The Dark Side,” emerged as another dominant force built around physicality, turnovers, and elite efficiency. While both defenses played in completely different NFL eras, comparisons between the two quickly became a major topic among Seahawks fans and NFL media. This project uses advanced defensive metrics, era-adjusted analysis, and data visualization to compare the strengths, identities, and overall dominance of both defenses.

Data Analysis Process

Step 1: Ask

- What defensive traits define the 2013 Seahawks vs. the 2025 Seahawks?
- How do their takeaway profiles compare (interceptions, fumbles, total takeaways)?
- Which defense was more dominant relative to league average?
- Did the 2025 defense truly reach historically elite status, or does the Legion of Boom still stand alone?

Step 2: Prepare

Data Sources:

- nflfastR play-by-play data (2013 and 2025 NFL seasons)
- Official ESPN NFL team statistics for stat validation

Tools Used:

- R Studio
- nflfastR
- tidyverse
- Tableau

Key Metrics Selected:

- Points Allowed
- Defensive EPA per Play
- Takeaways
- Sacks
- Turnover Rate
- Explosive Plays Allowed (20+ yards)
- Red Zone Touchdown Rate Allowed
- Era-adjusted defensive metrics

Why These Metrics?:

The selected metrics were chosen to evaluate multiple aspects of defensive performance:

- Efficiency
- Scoring prevention
- Big-play prevention
- Turnover creation
- Situational defense
- Relative dominance compared to league averages

Step 3: Process

Full R Script is included in GitHub Repo

Data Cleaning & Preparation:

- Loaded 2013 and 2025 NFL play-by-play datasets using nflfastR
- Filtered all defensive plays where Seattle was the defensive team
- Removed missing EPA and scoring values where necessary
- Created season-level game summary tables for points allowed calculations
- Standardized metrics across both seasons for fair comparison

- Validated turnover totals against official NFL statistics

Feature Engineering / Calculations:

Created custom defensive metrics including:

- Era-adjusted points allowed
- Defensive EPA differential vs league average
- Turnover rate per defensive play
- Explosive play rate allowed
- Red zone touchdown rate allowed
- Opportunity metrics such as total plays and games played

Data Visualization Preparation

- Structured final datasets into Tableau-ready tables
- Combined raw statistics and adjusted metrics into dashboard-friendly formats
- Designed comparison tables and visuals optimized for storytelling and readability

Step 4: Analyze

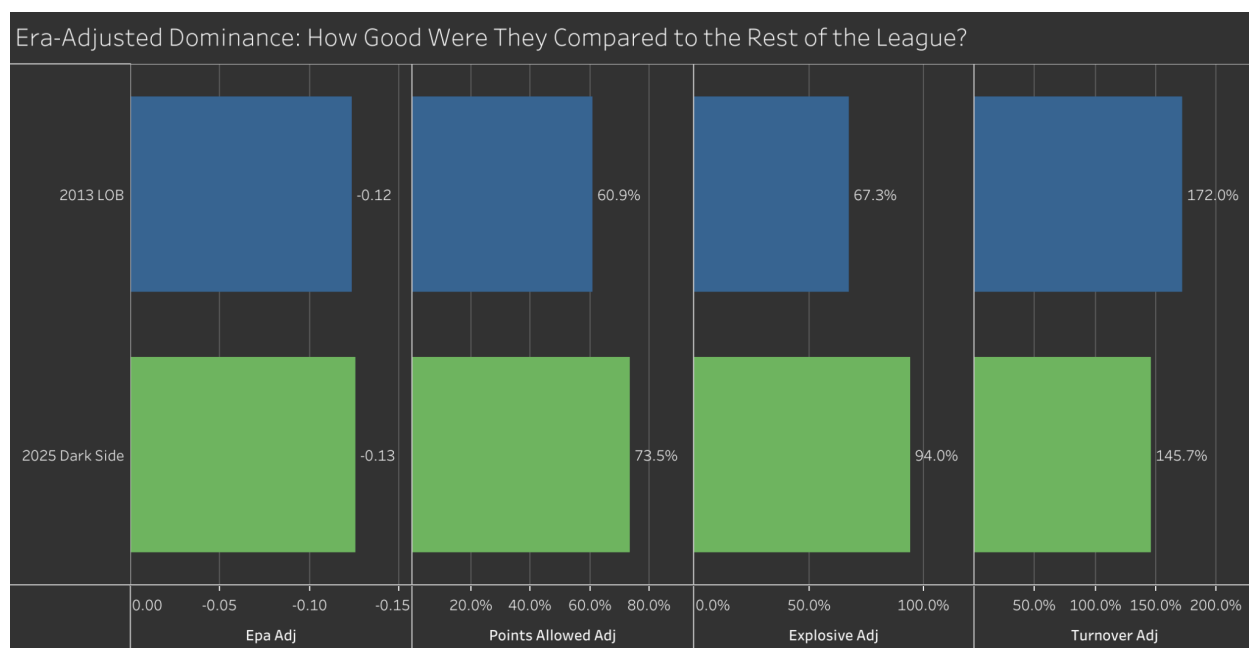
Key Findings

Legion of Boom (2013)

- Forced significantly more turnovers than the 2025 defense
- Elite explosive play prevention
- Historically dominant red zone defense
- Established one of the greatest defensive seasons in NFL history

The Darkside (2025)

- Produced nearly identical defensive EPA/play compared to the 2013 defense
- Excelled at down-to-down efficiency and limiting offensive success
- Generated elite defensive results despite playing in a more offense-friendly NFL era
- Demonstrated characteristics of a potential future defensive dynasty



*I decided not to include this chart on the final dashboard because I felt that it was a little too advanced for the casual audience that I was catering to. This full project report was designed for those who either love football, love analytics, or love both!

What do these era-adjusted stats mean?:

Legion of Boom (2013)

- Offenses performed ~0.12 EPA/play worse than league average against them
- Allowed ~39% fewer points than league average
- Allowed ~33% fewer explosive plays than league average
- Was 72% better than league average at forcing turnovers

The Darkside (2025)

- Offenses performed ~0.13 EPA/play worse than league average against them
- Allowed 26.5% fewer points than league average
- Allowed 6% fewer explosive plays than league average
- Was ~46% better than league average at forcing turnovers

Step 5: Share

Final Deliverables

- Tableau dashboard:
 - “Legion of Boom vs The Darkside”
- Comparative visualizations:
 - Takeaways/Sacks
 - Points Allowed
 - EPA/play comparison
 - Explosive plays allowed
 - Red zone defense
 - Opportunity Comparison
- Written analytical report summarizing findings and methodology

Dashboard Design Goals

- Blend sports storytelling with advanced analytics
- Create a cinematic “poster-style” dashboard inspired by modern sports media graphics
- Use visuals, player imagery, and Seahawks branding to enhance engagement
- Present advanced metrics in a way understandable to casual fans and analysts alike

See Below for Dashboard

Legion of Boom vs The Dark Side

A Defensive Comparison

2013 Seahawks

Historic. Physical. Unrelenting.
Potentially the Greatest Defense Ever



2025 Seahawks

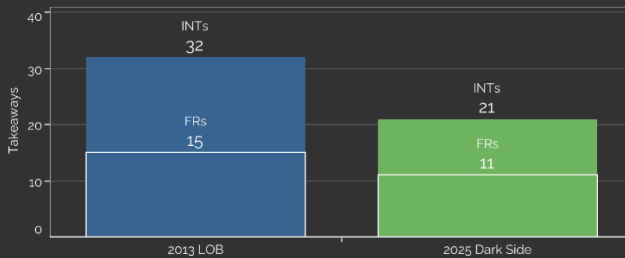
New Era. New Identity.
Seattle's Next Defensive Dynasty?

14.3	Points Allowed Per Game	16.9
47	Total Takeaways	32
48	Total Sacks	56
-0.12	EPA Per Play	-0.11

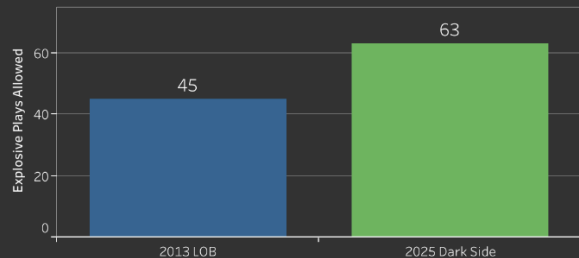
*EPA: Defensive EPA (Expected Points Added) measures how much each play changes the offense's expected points. Negative...

Ballhawks & Big Play Prevention

Takeaways (INTs & FRs)

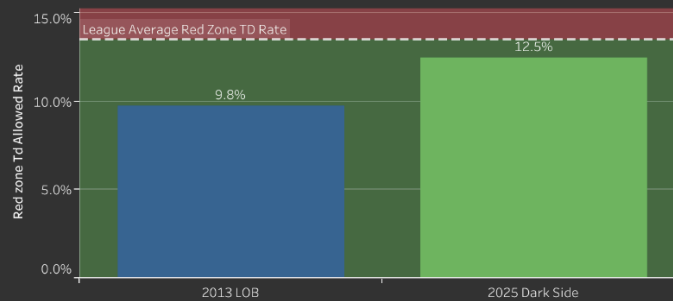


Explosive Plays Allowed (20+ Yards)



Goal Line Grit

Red Zone Defense (TD Rate)



*Defensive TD Rate: Opposing Offense's Chance of Scoring a TD on Any Given Red Zone Play

Opportunity

Key Takeaways

1563	Total Plays	1644
19	Games Played	20



The Legion of Boom Set the Standard.
The Darkside Is Chasing It

L.O.B.	Combined elite turnover creation with historic scoring prevention. More disruptive and opportunistic overall defensive profile
The Dark Side	Nearly identical defensive EPA efficiency despite playing in a more offense-friendly era. A modern defensive foundation with dynasty potential
Conclusion	The Legion of Boom was more dominant, but The Darkside proved Seattle's defensive standard still lives on

Step 6: Act

Answering My Questions

What defensive traits defined each defense?

The 2013 “Legion of Boom” defense was defined by elite turnover creation, explosive play prevention, and dominant red zone defense. Their ability to force mistakes and completely eliminate big plays made them one of the most feared defenses in NFL history.

The 2025 “Darkside” defense was defined more by efficiency and consistency. While they generated fewer takeaways, they got more sacks and performed nearly identically to the 2013 defense in defensive EPA/play, showing an elite ability to limit offensive success on a down-to-down basis in a more offense-friendly NFL era.

How did their takeaway profiles compare?

The 2013 Seahawks generated significantly more turnovers overall, finishing with higher totals in interceptions, fumble recoveries, and total takeaways. Their turnover rate was approximately 72% above league average, reinforcing their aggressive and disruptive identity.

The 2025 Seahawks still produced strong turnover numbers and remained well above league average, but relied less on takeaways and more on consistent defensive efficiency and situational stops.

Which defense was more dominant relative to league average?

The 2013 Seahawks were more dominant relative to league average in most defensive categories, particularly in points allowed, turnover creation, and explosive play prevention. Their ability to outperform the rest of the NFL in multiple areas helped solidify their place as one of the greatest defenses ever.

However, the 2025 Seahawks performed remarkably well in era-adjusted EPA/play metrics, suggesting they were equally dominant at limiting offensive efficiency despite playing in a modern NFL built heavily around passing and scoring.

Did the 2025 defense reach historically elite status?

The analysis suggests that the 2025 “Darkside” defense absolutely reached historically elite status and belongs in the conversation among Seattle’s greatest defenses. While the 2013 Legion of Boom still stands as the stronger overall unit due to its overwhelming turnover production and

explosive play suppression, the similarities in efficiency metrics show that the 2025 defense was closer to the Legion of Boom than a lot of fans initially believed.

Rather than replacing the Legion of Boom, the 2025 defense appears to represent the foundation of Seattle's next great era of defense.

What I Learned

Through this project, I gained valuable experience working through the complete data analytics process, from defining a question to building a final interactive dashboard. One of the biggest lessons I learned was the importance of context when comparing teams across different eras. Raw statistics alone can often be misleading, which is why era-adjusted metrics and league-relative comparisons became a major focus of the analysis.

I also strengthened my technical skills in R Studio, nflfastR, and Tableau by cleaning play-by-play data, calculating custom defensive metrics, and designing visualizations focused on storytelling and audience engagement. In addition, I learned how advanced metrics such as EPA/play can reveal insights that traditional statistics may overlook, while also recognizing the importance of balancing advanced analytics with easily understandable visuals and explanations.

Most importantly, this project reinforced how powerful sports analytics can be in telling deeper stories about teams, players, and historical comparisons. It allowed me to combine my passion for Seattle sports and football with data analysis in a way that is both meaningful and engaging.

Final Takeaway

The data supports the idea that Seattle's 2025 "Darkside" defense was not simply a great modern defense, but a unit capable of being legitimately compared to the legendary Legion of Boom. While the 2013 defense still sets the gold standard for overall dominance, the emergence of another historically elite Seahawks defense may signal the beginning of a new era in Seattle football.